



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: St. Therese Classical Academy
School Website: <https://stcacademy.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

St. Therese Classical Academy (Chester, NY, 10918) presents a largely classical profile with strong religious/theological framing, a formation-centered mission, and a pedagogy oriented toward Socratic discourse within a liberal-arts, Catholic context. Public materials regularly emphasize truth, goodness, and beauty; a faith-centered environment; and a commitment to classical methods (e.g., Socratic seminars, “great conversation,” and references to a Great Books–style tradition within the Chesterton network). There are explicit signs of classical aims (incarnational environment, formation through virtue, emphasis on memory work and liturgical cadence in some classical pedagogy materials) but the public-facing content also leaves several classical elements less explicit (e.g., granular statements about grammar/logic/rhetoric as a curricular core; full articulation of a systematic Great Books program; and fully detailed evidence of laid-out “memory/recitation” practices). Taken together, the school overall reads as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, with clear CLASSICAL signals in several areas and more contingent signals in others.

Key takeaways:

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations are strongly present (Christ-centered, faith-based formation, incarnational imagery) and supported by mission language and Chesterton-network references. This category is CLASSICAL.
- School Purpose and Goal is formation-oriented (virtue, wisdom, truth/beauty) with a clear “formation over information” stance cited in public materials. This category is CLASSICAL.
- Curriculum signals are present (liberal arts framing, Great Books/Great Conversation linkage via Chesterton network, and emphasis on wonder), but explicit curricular specifics (grammar/logic/rhetoric, full Great Books roster) are not consistently spelled out on the public pages. This category is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Pedagogy highlights Socratic dialogue and a contemplative (Scholastic-like) rhythm in some materials, but concrete evidence of a comprehensive restful pace and explicit memorization/recitation practices is limited in public content. This category is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Faculty signals include founder-led instruction and a culture of mentorship implied by “teacher-led” mission and the founder’s biography, but explicit statements about the faculty as “living curriculum” or a formal teacher portrait are not clearly articulated in public pages. This category is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.
- Parents & Community emphasis shows family orientation and opportunities for engagement (open houses, tours, and family-centered messaging), consistent with a partnership model; however, explicit, recurring statements about parents as co-teachers and a formal parent-formation program are less overt in the public content. This category is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public text frames the environment as Christ-oriented and faith-based: “in a stable, family and Christ oriented environment” for K-12 education. This demonstrates a religious/metaphysical foundation.
- Mission and philosophy emphasize orthodox Christian formation and a pursuit of truth, goodness, and beauty as central aims.

- Chesterton-network pages highlight “Incarnational Environment” and a Focus on Truth, Goodness and Beauty, signaling liturgical/theological scaffolding in education.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Christ-oriented environment, Faith, Incarnational, Truth, Goodness, Beauty, Theology (as implied by Catholic/Christ-centered framing), liturgical resonance, sacred orientation (implicit in “Incarnational”).
- Negative keywords: None evident in public content (no explicit relativism, secularism, or values-neutral signals observed in the excerpted material).

Why this rating

- The school publicly situates education within a Christ-centered, faith-grounded framework with explicit references to truth, goodness, and beauty and incarnational language, which strongly aligns with CLASSICAL signals in this category.

Citations: Christ-oriented environment; faith framing; incarnational language; truth/goodness/beauty emphasis.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The mission emphasizes a formation-focused aim (formation of character, wisdom, virtue) over mere information or job preparation; the public content notes “a quality liberal and fine arts education” in a faith-centered setting, with language about thinking rather than indoctrination: “teaches children how to think, not what to think.”
- Public materials repeatedly reference liberal and fine arts education, cultivation of wisdom/virtue, and a telos aligned with truth/goodness/beauty.
- The Chesterton-network materials emphasize “The Lost Tools of Learning,” Socratic seminars, and a focus on “truth, goodness, and beauty,” signaling a formation-driven purpose rather than vocationally narrow aims.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, liberal education, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, scholé (implied by the tradition and phrases like “great conversation”).
- Negative keywords present: None evident in public content (no explicit emphasis on job-readiness, 21st-century skills, or workforce metrics in these pages).

Why this rating

- The public materials foreground formation, virtue, and the transcendentals in alignment with classical aims, supporting a CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Citations: formation and virtue; liberal arts; pursuit of truth/beauty; formation over information; Great Conversation/Socratic framing in Chesterton materials.

Element 3: Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school presents a liberal-arts framing (K–12) and explicitly references the Chesterton network’s approach (including “Rediscovering the Lost Tools of Learning,” and a focus on a great conversation and Socratic engagement). The site also notes a liberal arts curriculum and the performing arts.
- Public materials emphasize a Great-Books/Great-Conversation orientation via Chesterton-linked messaging, “The Socratic Seminar,” and a deliberate alignment with classical pedagogy (though explicit mention of grammar/logic/rhetoric as core curricular pillars is not consistently documented on the public pages).

- The materials note “Education PreK-12, Liberal Arts, in the Hudson Valley,” signaling a broad liberal-arts approach and cross-disciplinary aims.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: liberal arts, Great Books (implied via Chesterton network and “Lost Tools of Learning”), Great Conversation/Socratic Seminar, memory/recitation ideas (implied through classical pedagogy in the network, e.g., “Socratic Seminar,” “The Lost Tools of Learning”).
- Negative keywords present: None explicit in public content (no counter-signals like overreliance on social studies-only history, or project-based-only emphasis documented on these pages).

Why this rating

- The curriculum signals align with core classical elements (liberal arts framing, great books/conversation via Chesterton network, and Socratic engagement). However, explicit, granular statements about grammar/logic/rhetoric as formal curricular keystones and a full Great Books roster are not consistently spelled out on the public pages. Given those gaps, this category is rated SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Citations: liberal arts framing; Chesterton network signals; Socratic Seminars; “Rediscovering the Lost Tools of Learning.”

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials reference Socratic Seminar as a core practice in the Chesterton Academy portion of the program, indicating a move toward dialectic and inquiry-based pedagogy.
- The presence of “Socratic Seminar” and “The Lost Tools of Learning” in the Chesterton context signals a classical pedagogy, though the pages reviewed do not consistently spell out a full spectrum of pedagogy (restful/scholé days, memorization/recitation, or a master-teacher model) in every section.
- The site highlights an experiential, inquiry-driven approach in the Chesterton network, but explicit, comprehensive articulation of a fully formed “restful learning” (Scholé) pace or a strong emphasis on memorization/recitation is not consistently documented on the public pages we reviewed.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue/seminar; great conversation; rhetoric and dialectic (via Chesterton/Seminars); formation through inquiry.
- Negative keywords present: None explicitly observed on these public pages that signal a total departure from classical methods (e.g., “experiential learning only,” “project-based-only” language is not the dominant framing on the STCA pages we saw).

Why this rating

- The pedagogy is strongly oriented toward Socratic inquiry and classical dialogue in parts of the school (Chesterton component), but a fully articulated pedagogy that covers all six positive pedagogy cues (Scholé/restful pace, memorization/recitation, master-teacher model, rhetoric training, upper-school public speaking opportunities, etc.) is not comprehensively present in the public materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for pedagogy.

Citations: Socratic Seminar; “Lost Tools of Learning” framing; Chesterton network pedagogy signals.

Element 5: Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Public materials identify STCA’s founder (Terri Raciti) and describe a leadership profile with decades of classroom experience, indicating a strong teaching backbone and mentorship orientation. The founder’s biography emphasizes the mission-driven, teacher-centered leadership.

- The public pages present teachers as part of the school's mission and operations, with the implication of teachers actively shaping the school's direction and culture. While the explicit phrase "living curriculum" or a formal "portrait of a teacher" is not clearly spelled out on the pages we examined, the emphasis on a founder-teacher led environment and mission-driven teaching signals a classical faculty ethos.
- Public content depicts a professional, teacher-led environment, with a focus on forming students and guiding learning, which aligns with a classical faculty portrait to some degree.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: model teachers and mentors, living curriculum, portrait of teacher/student ideal (both implied through founder-led mission and teacher-centric language); masterful teachers, character formation by teachers (implied through mission and teacher leadership).
- Negative keywords present: No explicit statements about non-classical faculty models (e.g., "facilitator on the sideline" or non-classical jargon) appearing in the public content we reviewed.

Why this rating

- The school demonstrates strong teacher-centered leadership and mentorship in public content, aligning with classical ideals in spirit, but explicit, standardized public claims about the faculty as a "living curriculum" or a formal faculty portrait are not clearly documented in the accessible pages. This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL for the Faculty category.

Citations: founder-led mission; teacher experience; mission-driven teaching emphasis.

Element 6: Parents & Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The materials emphasize a family-oriented environment and the involvement of families within a Catholic classical frame (e.g., a stable, family-centered environment). This signals partnership with families as a curricular and cultural feature.
- Open House/School Tours content and opportunities to schedule visits indicate that parents are welcome to explore the school, which aligns with a community-friendly stance and parent involvement.
- There is visible emphasis on fundraising and donor engagement (e.g., accreditation, donations), implying a broader community engagement ecosystem. While this demonstrates external engagement, it's not a direct, explicit restatement of parents as "co-teachers" or a formal parent-formation program on the public pages reviewed.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, family and community orientation, parent involvement, open campus, parent events, parent formation (as implied by presence of family-centric messaging and engagement opportunities).
- Negative keywords present: Not overtly present in the public content we examined (no language describing parents strictly as customers or minimal involvement).

Why this rating

- The site communicates a family-friendly orientation and invites parental involvement, placing it in the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL range for Parents & Community. The absence of explicit, sustained, formal statements about parents as co-teachers or a robust parent-formation program reduces it from CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Citations: family-oriented mission; open house and parent visitation signals; community engagement pieces.

Overall assessment (aggregate): SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Rationale: The school demonstrates multiple CLASSICAL signals (Catholic/theological grounding, formation emphasis, Socratic pedagogy within Chesterton networks, liberal-arts curriculum framing) but several

core, explicit classical elements are less consistently documented in public pages (clear articulation of grammar/logic/rhetoric as curricular pillars; fully detailed Great Books program; a comprehensive, restfully paced Scholé strategy; explicit “living curriculum” faculty statements). Taken together, the aggregate leans SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle (needle-moving recommendations for a fully CLASSICAL profile)

- Curriculum depth and clarity: Explicitly articulate grammar, logic, and rhetoric as core curricular pillars across grades K–12, with concrete examples of how students engage with those disciplines (and how these connect to Great Books and the Great Conversation). Include a published roster of Great Books titles and a bi-directional mapping to the Trivium/Quadrivium in appropriate grades.
- Great Books and Great Conversation: Strengthen and publicly document an explicit Great Books sequence and Great Conversation framework, with direct references to primary texts and authors across the history of Western civilization.
- Scholé and contemplative pedagogy: Provide a public, explicit statement of a restful pace (Scholé), including schedules, memory work, recitation, and contemplative time; show how contemplative practice is integrated into daily routines, not just occasional mentions.
- Memorization/Recitation: Reintroduce explicit memory-work practices (chanting, recitation, poetry, catechesis) with documented examples and outcomes, so the public materials reveal a robust public-facing architecture for this aspect of pedagogy.
- Faculty as living curriculum: Develop and publish a formal “portrait of the teacher” and a clear statement about faculty as the living curriculum, with professional development aligned to classical pedagogy.
- Parental partnership and formation: Implement and publicly showcase a robust parent-formation program (book studies, lectures, and home-based catechesis aligned to classical formation) to elevate parents from participation to co-teaching partnership.
- History and interdisciplinarity: Ensure historical study is woven throughout the curriculum as a cross-disciplinary throughline rather than as stand-alone segments, with explicit references to Western civilization and great books in multiple subjects.
- Explicit liturgical/communal practices: Integrate and publicly describe liturgical and communal practices (morning prayer, chapel time, liturgical calendar) to ground the liturgical dimension more clearly in day-to-day schooling.

ABSTRACT

St. Therese Classical Academy (Chester, NY, 10918) presents a CLASSICAL-inspired profile with explicit religious/theological framing and a formation-centric mission. Public materials emphasize truth, goodness, and beauty, a Christ-centered environment, and Socratic pedagogical elements via Chesterton-network messaging. While the school demonstrates substantial CLASSICAL signals in Categories 1 (Religious Foundations) and 2 (Purpose/Goal), and meaningful classical orientation in Element 3 (Curriculum) and Element 4 (Pedagogy), several core classical elements—such as explicit grammar/logic/rhetoric curricular structure, a fully detailed Great Books sequence, a comprehensive Scholé implementation, and a formal “living curriculum” portrayal of faculty—are not consistently and explicitly documented on the public-facing pages.

Category-by-category summary (overall): CLASSICAL in Element 1; SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in Categories 2–6; aggregated as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL Evidence: Christ-centered mission; Incarnational language; faith-rooted education; “truth, goodness, and beauty” framing. Positive Keywords: truth, goodness, beauty; faith/theology; incarnational/hearted; liturgical language (implied). No explicit negative signals observed.
- School Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL Evidence: Formation over information; education for wisdom/virtue; emphasis on thinking rather than indoctrination. Positive Keywords: formation, wisdom, virtue, liberal education, telos, pursuit of truth/goodness/beauty.

- Curriculum: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Liberal arts framing; Great Books/Great Conversation framing via Chesterton network; emphasis on wonder. Positive Keywords: liberal arts, Great Books, Great Conversation, Socratic Seminar, wonder.
- Pedagogy: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Socratic Seminar and classical dialogue emphasized; resting pace not explicitly documented on pages; other classical methods not consistently described. Positive Keywords: Socratic Seminar, dialectic, guided discussion.
- Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Founder-led mission and teacher experience; implicit mentorship orientation; explicit “living curriculum” statements are not widely documented in the public pages. Positive Keywords: experienced teachers; mentorship (implied).
- Parents & Community: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL Evidence: Family-centered language and open-house/tour signals; openness to parent involvement; not explicit about parents as co-teachers or formal parent formation. Positive Keywords: partnership with families; open campus; family involvement.

What would move the needle

- Publicly codify and publish concrete, granular evidence for each classical element: grammar/logic/rhetoric as curricular staples; a detailed Great Books sequence; explicit Scholé/restful pacing; explicit memorization/recitation practices; a formal living-curriculum faculty portrait; and a formalized, ongoing parent formation program with clear co-teaching roles. These changes would elevate the overall classification to CLASSICAL across all six categories.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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